

Exhaustivity and Contrastivity in Hungarian Pre-Verbal Focus Constructions: A Visual-World Study



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Keywords: focus construction, exhaustivity, contrastivity, visual-world paradigm, Hungarian

Abstract:

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Paper Decision

Decision by Program Chairs 13 Feb 2026, 04:54 (modified: 17 Feb 2026, 00:05)
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Decision: Reject

All in all, the abstract offers clear experimental data on the exhaustivity issue, but it doesn't exploit them to offer clear answers to the hottest theoretical questions raised at the beginning.

Official Review by Reviewer hij6 07 Jan 2026, 03:18 (modified: 17 Feb 2026, 00:03)
 Program Chairs, Senior Area Chairs, Reviewer hij6, Authors Revisions (/revisions?id=RCrLTcFqIM)

Review:

Exhaustivity and Contrastivity in Hungarian Pre-Verbal Focus Constructions: A Visual-World Study

The abstract presents a novel experiment on the exhaustive reading of preverbal focus in Hungarian based on sentence picture verification and eye-tracking. The design of the experiment is sound, and the results are clear and presented properly. Yet, the whole picture is quite disappointing, for the conclusions of the experiment “suggest” the very same description of the data in (1), namely that by default preverbal focus is interpreted exhaustively, and something extra is needed for obtaining a contrastive reading. While confirming experimentally the mainstream description of the facts is a good thing, the main theoretical question that was raised at the beginning of the abstract, i.e. whether the exhaustive reading of focus was a semantic or a pragmatic feature, should be addressed more properly and developed a bit more. For example, the final line makes a bold claim that the exhaustive bias is the product of “online disambiguation of an underspecified structure”. Which is this underspecified structure? Is exhaustivity semantically encoded in this structure, and contrast derived pragmatically? Are we talking about presuppositions, conventional implicatures or conversational implicatures? Moreover, one would have appreciated a short comparison

of the results with previous experiments. All in all, the abstract offers clear experimental data on the exhaustivity issue, but it doesn't exploit them to offer clear answers to the hottest theoretical questions raised at the beginning.

Rating: 5: Marginally below acceptance threshold

Confidence: 3: The reviewer is fairly confident that the evaluation is correct

Interesting data, only fit for a poster presentation

Official Review by Reviewer f136 📅 05 Jan 2026, 18:42 (modified: 17 Feb 2026, 00:03)

👁 Program Chairs, Senior Area Chairs, Reviewer f136, Authors 📄 Revisions (/revisions?id=PsV7pk3Slc)

Review:

I think this abstract is more suited for a poster presentation than a talk: the phenomenon is well known in the literature, and the experimental design is clear. The experiment is sound and the results are relevant to the issue of the nature of preverbal focus in Hungarian.

One issue that is left open, at the theoretial level, is why the exhaustivity reading is predominant. As the results suggest a pragmatic explanation, the authors might consider the idea that the PVF sentences are interpreted as answers to an implicit question under discussion.

Rating: 8: Top 50% of accepted papers, clear accept

Confidence: 5: The reviewer is absolutely certain that the evaluation is correct and very familiar with the relevant literature

Well presented but no theoretical consequences

Official Review by Reviewer 4TSe 📅 01 Jan 2026, 17:25 (modified: 17 Feb 2026, 00:03)

👁 Program Chairs, Senior Area Chairs, Reviewer 4TSe, Authors 📄 Revisions (/revisions?id=mtuZgSUIQM)

Review:

The paper provides a well presented experimental study on the exhaustivity of focus in Hungarian. Unfortunately, the paper does not start with a reasonable theoretical hypothesis or question but rather just ask a general question about human behavior in the face of simple linguistic stimuli. The design provides no way to disentangle theoretical approaches and does not provide any interesting theoretical discussion either. While the results are genuinely interesting, they are not framed properly and thus the paper cannot be accepted.

Rating: 2: Strong rejection

Confidence: 5: The reviewer is absolutely certain that the evaluation is correct and very familiar with the relevant literature

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